

New York passes 1K COVID-19 deaths; hospitalization rate falls

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NEW YORK — New York state's coronavirus death toll is nearing 1,000, Gov. Andrew Cuomo said. The state accounts for more than 40% of coronavirus deaths in the U.S.

New York City reported in the evening that its toll had risen to 776. The total number of statewide deaths isn't expected to be released until Monday, but with at least 250 additional deaths recorded outside the city as of Sunday morning, the state's total fatalities was at least 1,026.

The vast majority have been in New York City. Figures released Sunday morning showed 678 coronavirus deaths in the city, which continues to be the epicenter of the pandemic in the U.S.

Meanwhile, new data is showing which parts of the city are being hit the hardest by disease and that nearly a quarter of the people who've died of coronavirus in the state were nursing home residents.

Coronavirus is overwhelming some of New York City's poorest neighborhoods, according to new data released by the city.

Queens accounts for 32% of the city's more than 30,000 confirmed cases as of Saturday — more than any other borough.

Neighborhoods such as Jackson Heights, Elmhurst and Corona, which are generally poor, densely packed and have large non-English speaking populations, have been among the hardest hit, according to a city map showing percent ranges of people testing positive for the disease, also known as COVID-19. In those areas, 69% to 86% of the tests done have come back positive.

A hospital in Elmhurst has been overrun with co-



MARY ALTAFFER/AP

A paramedic transports a patient into the Trauma Center at the Elmhurst Hospital Center on Sunday in New York.

ronavirus cases. One day last week, 13 hospital patients with the virus died.

Statistics on coronavirus cases do not reflect everyone who may have the virus, because many people have been told to manage their illness at home and are not getting tested.

The number of patients being discharged at the state's hospitals after they've been treated for coronavirus has increased daily to a high of 845 on Saturday, Cuomo said. In all, more than 3,500 people have been discharged.

As of Sunday, more than 8,500 people remain hospitalized across the state because of the disease, including more than 2,000 in intensive care. In New York City, about 20% of coronavirus cases have led to hospitalizations.

Those totals are continuing to spike, but Cuomo said they're not multiplying nearly as quickly as they were last week. From March 16 to 19, the number of hospitalizations in the state doubled every two days. Now it's taking about six days for the number to double.

On Saturday, after saying he was weighing the idea of a mandatory quarantine for New York, New Jersey and Connecticut, President Donald Trump tweeted that instead he'd issue advisory urging people in

those states to avoid any nonessential travel for two weeks.

New York City Mayor Bill de Blasio said he worried about the advisory's impact on families with members in New York and other places who were looking to reunite.

All 50 U.S. states have reported some cases of the virus that causes COVID-19, but New York state has the most, with over 52,000 positive tests.

On Sunday de Blasio reiterated his fears that without reinforcements the city will run out of masks, gowns and other hospital supplies in a week and ventilators sooner.

With the expected peak of cases in the city still two to three weeks away, de Blasio told CNN's "State of the Union" on Sunday that the city also needs new waves of doctors, nurses and other medical personnel.

"We need to get them relief," de Blasio said. "They can't keep up at this pace for weeks and weeks and weeks ahead and expect to save lives the way we need them to."

Cuomo said Sunday that more than 76,000 doctors, nurses and other health professionals, including many who've recently retired from the field, have volunteered to help in the coronavirus fight.